

API Versioning Strategies

Day 3 handout. The "evolve without breaking" guarantee. Three common strategies, their trade-offs, and the default. Pick one and document it — "we don't need versioning yet" defers a cost rather than removing one.

STRATEGY	WHERE THE VERSION LIVES	PROS	CONS
URL path	<code>/v1/...</code> <code>/v2/...</code>	Easy to read; clear breaking changes	Code duplication
Header	<code>X-API-Version: 2</code>	URL stays clean	Less discoverable
Content negotiation	<code>Accept: application/vnd.acme+json;v=2</code>	Standard	Often poorly understood

The default

For most B2B APIs, **URL path versioning** is the right default. It's the most discoverable and makes breaking changes explicit.

Document your choice

Versioning strategy: _____

Rationale: _____

Force the strategy choice **now**. Deferring it doesn't remove the cost — it just moves it to the first time you need a breaking change, when it's more expensive.